

represent the Byzantine tradition.¹ Having done that, what do the critics have left to work with? They are left with a handful of relatively early MSS that are so disparate that they cannot be grouped. They not only disagree with the majority, they disagree among themselves. They survived because they are so bad that no one wanted to use them. They have neither ‘parents’ nor ‘children’, which means that they were private productions and not honest copies; they are not part of a line of transmission.

So what do the critics do when those few MSS disagree among themselves? They ask: Which reading best explains the creation of the others? So what criteria do they use to arrive at that conclusion? They ask questions like these:

1. Which is the oldest MS?
2. Which is the ‘best’ MS?
3. Which is the shorter reading?
4. Which is the ‘harder’ reading?
5. Which reading best agrees with the author’s style and purpose?

Question 1) is based on the analogy of a stream, whose water will be purest at the source; the greater the distance from the source, the more contaminants the water will have. However, with reference to NT MSS the analogy is certainly false. It is generally agreed that most of the damage suffered by the NT text had happened by the year 200, the date ascribed to our earliest MSS of any size (P⁶⁶). So our earliest MSS could be full of ‘damage’.

Question 2): They generally declare Codex B (Vaticanus, 03) to be the ‘best’ extant MS. What is the basis for their claim? Hort, based on his subjective preferences (including the early date), declared B to be by far the ‘best’ MS, and subsequent critics have generally fallen in line with that dictum. But is there any objective basis for the claim? So far as I know, there is none; the objective evidence available says the contrary. (My evaluation applies to all other early MSS as well.)

Questions 3) and 4) are totally naturalistic, excluding any theological or supernatural considerations whatsoever. Hort imported them from the Alexandrian school’s procedure for arriving at the original wording of Homer. Anyone who has collated any number of NT MSS, as I have done,

¹ Having rejected the divine inspiration of the NT, they of course reject any divine solicitude for that text. Those who deny the very existence of a Sovereign Creator will logically insist that a nonexistent being cannot do anything.